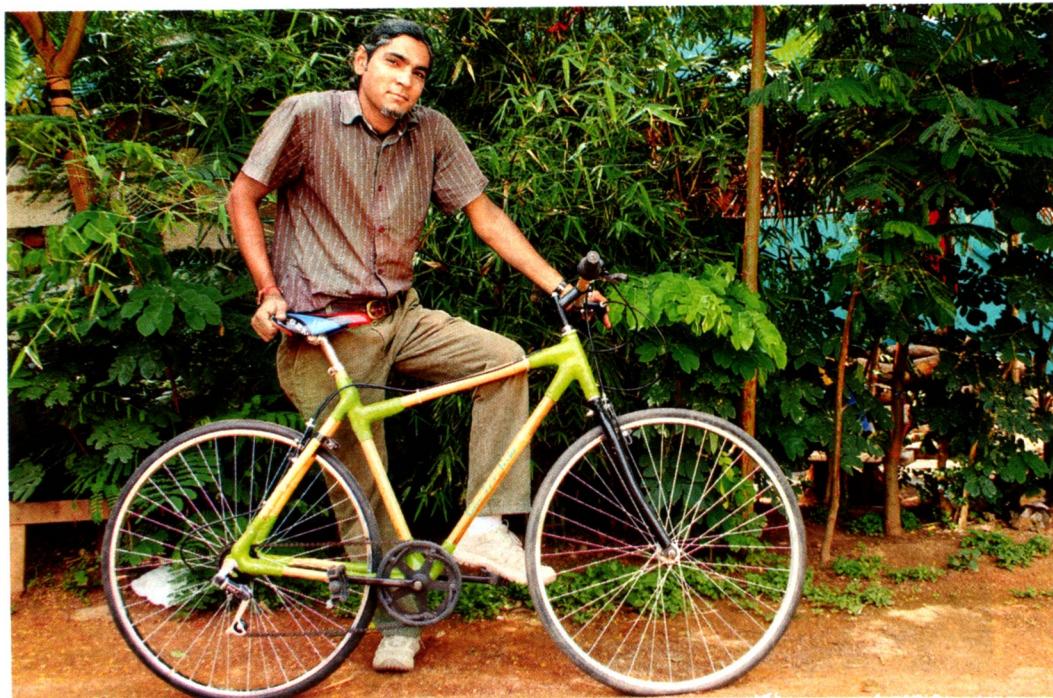


Beyond Recycling

KARNATAKA
BANGALORE

A bicycle made of bamboo and glass fibre does the job as well, and at a lower cost to the environment



PANKSHI RAO

SHARMA POSES
WITH HIS BICYCLE

| By Swagata Sen |

A steely resolve to make but a small difference is what drives Vijay Sharma, 34, an otherwise regular guy. Sharma, a manufacturer of office furniture, has developed a bicycle made of bamboo and fibre by replacing 3.5 kg of steel in the usual kind. His cycle can withstand bumpy rides, and has global enthusiasts interested. "If we mass produce this, it could prevent so many tonnes of iron ore being converted to steel to manufacture cycles, and thus, even fewer emissions," says Sharma. For now, he has set up a workshop in Nagpur under the supervision of his friend Vaibhav Kaley. They are starting small, making only 10 such bicycles initially, each of which will sell for Rs 10,000, almost the same as a medium quality regular bicycle with gears. "After we see how viable it is, we will start producing it on a bigger scale," says Sharma.

After studying interior designing at the Centre for Environmental Planning and Technology, Ahmedabad, Sharma moved to Bangalore in 2002. He first developed a tricycle, or trike, different from a cycle-rickshaw in its placement of two wheels in front and one at the back. Fitted with a comfortable seat and sunroof, it comes in a

two-seater variant too, costing about Rs 25,000.

About four months ago, Kaley had asked Sharma to design a bicycle of bamboo for one of his friends. Sharma scoured the Internet for three months, added a few of his own ideas and made his bike in three days. The frame and handles were made of bamboo, and while he used conventional material for the brakes, chain and tyres, glass fibre replaced nuts and bolts to join the frame. At 15 kg, it weighs 2 kg less than conventional bicycles but does not fall short on features, like gears. "Bamboo has better shock-absorbing power for rough roads, but we're trying to make a stiffer version for smooth roads," says Sharma.

Sharma, however, wasn't prepared for the overwhelming response after a friend posted pictures on the Net. Bike makers from Europe made enquiries and US-based bamboo bike designer Craig Calfee proposed collaboration. "But I want to do this on my own," he says. Calfee's designs cost \$500-\$3,000, Sharma, however, wants his to be affordable and sees an opportunity to employ bamboo artisans too. At the end of the day he wants to pedal home knowing that he has made a difference. ■